

The children who exercise the most self-control often use distracting techniques to avoid eating the marshmallow. The techniques vary but include singing as well as different variations of blocking the marshmallow from their sight, such as hiding under the table, closing their eyes, putting their heads on the table or simply looking away. In a subsequent experiment, the children are placed in the room in pairs and given the single marshmallow with the same instruction. In this instance, they either encourage or discourage self-control in each other.

Now, self-control or self-regulation (or discipline) might not seem revolutionary or exciting, but its effects on our finances are.

Let's suppose we swap out marshmallows for debt, credit cards or buy-now-pay-later platforms? Or what if we swapped out marshmallows for a holiday overseas, a wellness experience, the latest must-have handbag or the latest tech gadget? What if we swapped it for our propensity to dip into our savings? Or to engage in some sneaky shopping when we're stressed?

How many of you have been quick to eat your financial equivalent of the marshmallow? Or been encouraged by a friend, a family member or the media to eat it? Or encouraged another friend to eat theirs so that you felt better about yourself and your own financial bingeing?

That's what I thought.

Encouragingly, the results from the Dunedin Study suggest that simply because we've engaged in a particular set of destructive behaviours up until now, it doesn't mean this will always be our behaviour in the future.

Researchers at first discovered that self-control can be improved in children but ultimately determined that it could also be developed as adults. We can see this illustrated best through a subset of children in the study. Ten per cent of the children were identified at age three as having an 'undercontrolled personality'. These children were often highly strung, didn't cope well with novelty and change, were usually quick to anger and struggled with self-control. The parents who consistently encouraged structure and routine found they were able to cancel out the undisciplined effects of their child's undercontrolled personality. But the researchers discovered that self-control could also be encouraged and learned by those with this type of personality at any age with the right regulation and intervention.